

Must-have App: Gravitux

Use your finger to create gravitational fields, and move the stars around your screen. You're supposed to create art, but it's really just an excellent time-killer (Free)

book, even. Take a tablet that size and that weight to read in bed, and watch it tip over in your hand and bonk you on the nose. Not the type to read in bed, are you? Well, how about this: the shiny front bezel will ensure that no matter how you try to grip it, your thumb will slowly slip towards the edge, forcing you to hold the iPad in both hands. If you can picture yourself doing this – i.e. in a chair, worrying that it may fall if you aren't ever-vigilant – you might see that it's a rather stupid position for reading; something, I must remind you, that people do to relax.

What about writing then? With the keyboard dock, perhaps. But since I couldn't be arsed to spend any money on that, I was stuck with the on-screen keyboard. I should point out that I'm biased here: I've always maintained that anyone who trades in a physical keyboard for a touchscreen travesty should be tied naked to a nest of angry hornets, so it's no surprise how much I dislike the iPad's keyboard. But I can't imagine anyone *liking* it – just tolerating it in various degrees. In portrait mode, it's too big to use with thumbs, but too small for both hands. In landscape, it's big enough to use with both hands. I can use it without cursing by now, but it's still horrible, and I'm getting a keyboard dock as soon as I can convince someone to buy me one.

Okay, so maybe it is a really big iPod Touch. But can that be a good thing?

The good thing

It's the screen. It's bright, beautiful, responsive (although that has to do with the processor as well), and is perfect when viewed from every angle. And big. And the bigness is good. Good for browsing the Web, reading PDFs, and when turned off, checking for bits of food in your moustache before that important presentation.

But where the screen truly excels is games. Not the little iPhone/iPod Touch games, where you're tilting and shaking the device, of course – you don't tilt and shake a \$500, 650-gram device that threatens to fall out of your hands every time you lift it up. I'm talking good, old-fashioned tabletop games. The screen supports up to 11 fingers (or 10 fingers

and the tip of your nose), making it the closest you'll come to that Surface thing that Microsoft promised and then threw down a black hole. Fire up Game Table (free in the App Store), lay the iPad on your table, and have a game of Chess (or Checkers, or Reversi) with a friend. Play Harbor Master HD (also free) for endless hours, and have your friends help you dock those boats without crashing. Join a friend in the tower defense extravaganza that is Plants and Zombies. See the common thread here? The iPad's screen is a compelling reason to get back in touch with all those



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people you've alienated since you found the Internet. Or alternatively, get yourself a gimp.

But beneath the starry veneer, there are still things that smell.

The gripes

Someone needs to tell Steve Jobs that I'm a big boy now. That means I get to take responsibility for my decisions, even if they seem like the actions of a whimsical monkey on LSD. I should be able to install apps that "ruin my experience", as long as I acknowledge that I only have myself to blame when my iPad crashes. Is that so hard? Anyway, let's not beat this dead horse any more.

What's really getting on my nerves lately is the lack of a common file storage. It would be presumptuous of me to

trouble you, Apple, for a Finder-like utility to browse the iPad's file system, but surely you could just make a common pool of files that every app could dip into, couldn't you? Transferring files to apps through iTunes is groovy and all, but how about letting the apps share those files properly? Consider what I'm dealing with: I'm reading a PDF in GoodReader, when I realise I want to make a couple of annotations in iAnnotate. In GoodReader, I can choose to open that file in iAnnotate (also groovy). But here's the catch

– iAnnotate gets a *copy* of the PDF, not the original. This repeats every time I try to use this "open with" feature. So when I'm done annotating and want to send it back to GoodReader, I now have my original PDF and an annotated copy, and an annotated copy still in iAnnotate. You could argue that I should do everything in one app and stop whining, but there's a reason I use two. GoodReader, for instance, doesn't die when I throw huge PDFs at it. And now with iBooks supporting PDFs as well, I may end up with another copy for that, too. And before you know it, the apps are spawning more copies than a collection of bunnies during mating season.

I understand that apps need to run in their own sandboxes and not mess with other apps' toys, but don't sell it as a device for (potential) productivity if you're going to get in the way of me getting productive.

But maybe that's been my mistake all along.

The point

The iPad, as the tech pundits will tell you, is a great device "for consuming media". You know, like your TV. You're supposed to stare gormlessly into its magical screen, drooling onto your shirt, watching YouTube and surfing the Internet looking for bandwagons to jump on. Productivity? What kind of square are you, daddy-o? This is a thing for the cool kids, who don't need to work, because mommy told them that the world will bow before them anyway.

On the other hand, revision 2 might turn out to be rather nice. 